

The Worlds of the Nunnehi

The Nunnehi believe in three “worlds” that make up all of creation: the Upper World, the Middle World, and the Lower World.

The Upper World is the realm of spirits. The Higher Hunting Grounds, the Nunnehi realms within Arcadia, are cut off to them, but they can still enter the Upper World to interact with spirits. The different Families interact with the Upper world to varying degrees. Some, such as the surems and kachinas, spend a great deal of time there, conducting rituals and speaking with the spirits. Others, such as the rock giants and tunghat are more grounded in the Middle World. Other beings of the night, such as werewolves and mages, know the Upper World as the Umbra.

The Middle World is the physical realm. Most humans spend their entire lives in the Middle World, unaware that any other worlds exist around them.

The Lower World is the realm of the dead. Few Nunnehi have direct interactions with this realm, though they are all aware of its existence. It is believed that once, long ago, the nanhehi traveled the Lower World and acted as guides for recently-deceased mortal spirits, guiding them on their proper path and preventing them from becoming hungry ghosts. However, this ability was lost along with their connection to the Higher Hunting Grounds.

closely mirrored that of the mortal tribes. Though these new fae appreciated the beautiful surroundings, they could not glean Glamour from it as could the Nunnehi. Unwittingly, these settlers often felled stands of ancient trees, dammed streams, and plowed over fields where the Nunnehi once danced and gathered Medicine. Warfare also broke out among the Nunnehi – tribe fought tribe as they were pushed into one another’s territories and forced into competition for resources. During the War for Independence, many Native Americans sided with the European powers rather than the Americans, hoping that the Europeans would return their lands in exchange for their help. The Nunnehi fought alongside their mortal brothers and sisters and shared their fate. When the war was lost, these Nunnehi, and all associated with them, were severely punished. Many were killed outright or forced into slavery, and the rest were stripped of their remaining lands.

The pattern of atrocities against the native tribes and the Nunnehi continued as Europeans spread westward. Whole tribes were decimated by diseases or displaced from their hunting grounds and homelands. Many Nunnehi, who had formerly been peaceful, responded with anger and enmity, waging war on the Kithain and their human kin. Others withdrew deep into the wilderness, hoping to hide from the encroachment of the Europeans. Some accompanied the mortal tribes into exile.

To this day, some Nunnehi continue to attack and fight the usurpers of their lands. Their once-free glens, which served as dancing circles and meeting places, have been taken for freeholds, or built up into strip malls and office buildings. Until recently, many Nunnehi were nomadic, moving according to the seasons. The world has changed since the arrival of European mortals and fae and the Nunnehi have been forced to adapt. Where once they lived in the wilds and were in many ways closer to the Inanimae, they now live amongst the mortals, hidden in the same manner as the Kithain.

For the last 100 years, the Nunnehi have been in decline as the population of the mortal tribes dwindles, and they continue to shun the old beliefs and turn away from the ancient traditions. The last few decades have seen a resurgence of Native American pride and a rekindling of interest in the old ways. From the renaissance of belief has arisen a new hope that the Nunnehi are no longer a dead and dying people, but one that has endured a long winter and is now emerging into spring.

Return of the Sidhe

The return of the noble sidhe complicated matters even further. Their arrival and the reclamation of lands they considered to be their fiefs not only sparked the Accordance War, but acted as a call to arms for the Nunnehi Nations as well. Some Nunnehi again found themselves displaced by this influx of non-natives, who once again assumed their own superiority. Many Nunnehi fought alongside the commoners, believing that once they triumphed, the common Kithain would recognize their rights. Other Nunnehi stood aside, feeling that it was none of their concern if commoner slew noble. A few sided with the sidhe, remembering a time when some nobles swore treaties and professed bonds of friendship with them. These last fared the best, and some Nunnehi Nations today enjoy treaties and guarantees of their rights sworn by nobles who have claimed fiefdoms, partly won with aid from their Nunnehi allies.

Naturally, nothing is without a price. Conflicts between the tribes engendered by the Accordance War have caused old enmities between the various Nunnehi tribes to erupt. The new emphasis on pride among the Native Americans has had a heady effect on the Nations. Where they all might once have been content to ally in the face of certain eventual destruction, the renewal of native culture has made them proud and unwilling to forgive old wrongs. Thus, even as the Nunnehi have again become strong, they weaken themselves by inter-tribal bickering.

Tribes

The Nunnehi are born from the dreams, beliefs, and expectations of the Native American tribes. Most Nunnehi are born to mortal members of one of the existing tribes. Those who are born outside of a Native American tribe are often lost, never awakened to their true potential, and even if they do awaken they will have no understanding of what they are.

Long ago, a particular Nunnehi identified only with a particular tribe, but over time they have come to associate with tribes in the same region that share similar backgrounds.